20 LAZY DINNERS SORTED BY HOW TIRED YOU ARE
WHAT'S FOR EATS | PRINTABLE DINNER GUIDE

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20 Lazy Dinners for When Your Brain Has Left the Building

Lazy dinner ideas sorted by how tired you are, with the number of dishes you'll wash on every one.

It's 5:47 p.m. and someone has just asked, "What's for dinner?" It's a pop quiz you didn't study for, with no notes, no warning and a very hungry audience. That's the moment this list is for.

Think of a recipe as the open-book version of dinner. You don't have to remember anything, invent anything or feel guilty about anything. You just follow the steps. These
lazy dinners
are sorted by

ener gy level

, so you pick the tier that matches how you actually feel, not how you wish you felt. Every dinner shows its
dish count
(how many pots, pans and bowls you'll wash), uses ordinary grocery-store shortcuts, and has a full step-by-step method, because even a lazy dinner shouldn't leave you guessing.

Let's be clear about something:
none of this is cheating
. A rotisserie chicken is a legitimate ingredient. A microwave rice pouch is a tool. Cereal for dinner is a choice, but you don't have to make it tonight.

Dish count:
the pots, pans, bowls and baking dishes you'll wash. Plates, cups and forks don't count, because we're not monsters.

Level 1: Five Minutes of Effort (the "I'm Basically a Houseplant" Tier)

You're running on fumes and the smell of dinner is a rumor. These need almost no cooking: you assemble, you microwave, you eat. If you can open a container, you qualify.

1. Rotisserie Chicken Plate (the Adult Lunchable)

Dishes to wash: 0 (just plates)

EFFORT: 5 MIN NO COOKING

Grocery stores sell fully cooked chicken with a handle. You are legally and morally

allowed to use it. Add some crunchy things and a dip, and it’s a dinner that looks like you meant it.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

1 store-bought rotisserie chicken, warm or cold

1 bag baby carrots

1 cucumber, sliced

1 container hummus (or ranch)

4 pitas or 1 sleeve crackers

1 bunch grapes or 2 apples

HOW TO MAKE IT

Open the chicken container. Wash your hands, then pull the meat off in big pieces, starting with the breast. The meat should come away easily, and the thigh and leg meat is the juicy part.

Slice the cucumber into coins. If slicing is too much, use mini cucumbers or snap peas and skip the knife.

Put the hummus in a small bowl (or just use a spoon and plop it on the plate).

Arrange the chicken, carrots, cucumber, pita and fruit on plates. Eat.

Put the leftover chicken and the carcass in the fridge right away. Chicken shouldn’t sit out more than 2 hours.

Even lazier:
Eat it straight off the plate with your hands. Nobody’s judging.

Good to know:
Save the carcass and any bones in a bag in the freezer. They’re free soup broth later.

2. 5-Minute Burrito Bowl

Dishes to wash: 1 bowl

EFFORT: 5 MIN MICROWAVE

This is a burrito that gave up on the tortilla and is happier for it. It all happens in a single bowl, which is also the bowl you eat from, so cleanup is a rinse and a prayer.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

1 microwave rice pouch (about 8.8 oz)

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained and rinsed

1 cup frozen corn

1/2 cup salsa

1 cup shredded cheese

Optional: avocado, sour cream, tortilla chips, lime

HOW TO MAKE IT

Microwave the rice pouch according to the package (usually about 90 seconds). Be careful when opening: the steam is hot.

In a large microwave-safe bowl, stir together the beans and frozen corn. Cover loosely with a paper towel and microwave 2 minutes, until hot.

Stir in the rice. Top with the cheese and microwave 30 seconds more, until melted.

Top with salsa and any extras. Crumble a few chips over the top for crunch.

Even lazier:
Skip the toppings except cheese and salsa. It’s still dinner.

Good to know:
Rinsing the beans removes the slimy canning liquid and some of the salt. Just run them under water in a strainer for 20 seconds.

3. Hummus Veggie Wraps

Dishes to wash: 0

EFFORT: 5 MIN NO COOKING

A wrap is just a sandwich that’s decided to be more portable. These take about as long as it takes to find your phone charger, and nothing needs cooking.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

4 large tortillas

1 cup hummus

2 cups baby spinach

1 cup shredded carrots (bagged)

1 cucumber, thinly sliced

1 cup shredded cheese or crumbled feta

Optional: 1 cup shredded rotisserie chicken

HOW TO MAKE IT

Lay a tortilla flat on a plate. Spread about 1/4 cup hummus over it, leaving a 1-inch border around the edge.

Pile on a handful of spinach, some carrots, cucumber and cheese (and chicken, if using). Don’t overfill, or the wrap will tear.

Fold the left and right sides in about an inch, then roll up from the bottom, tucking tightly as you go.

Cut in half on a diagonal and eat. Repeat for the rest.

Even lazier:
Skip the rolling. Make a taco-style fold and eat it like a floppy sandwich.

Good to know:
If the tortilla cracks when you fold it, warm it in the microwave for 15 seconds wrapped in a damp paper towel to make it bendy.

4. Upgraded Instant Ramen

Dishes to wash: 1 pot

EFFORT: 5 to 7 MIN STOVETOP

Instant ramen is a fine dinner, and it gets even better with an egg and some frozen peas. For about 90 extra seconds of effort, you’ve moved from "snack" to "meal." That’s a promotion.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

4 packs instant ramen noodles (with seasoning packets)

6 cups water

4 eggs

1 cup frozen peas or mixed vegetables

2 tbsp soy sauce

Optional: sesame oil, chili oil, sliced green onion

HOW TO MAKE IT

Bring the 6 cups of water to a boil in a large pot.

Add the noodles and frozen vegetables. Cook 2 to 3 minutes, gently loosening the noodles with a fork.

Carefully crack the eggs into the simmering broth, spaced apart. Let them cook, without stirring, 3 to 4 minutes, until the whites are completely set. (For firm yolks, cook 5 minutes.)

Stir in the soy sauce and half to all of the seasoning packets. Taste first, since the

packets are very salty.

Ladle into bowls, sliding an egg into each. Top with sesame oil or green onion if you have them.

Even lazier:
Eat it straight from the pot with a ladle and a spoon. Dish count: zero bowls.

Good to know:
Using only half the seasoning packet keeps the sodium down without losing much flavor.

5. Snack Board Dinner

Dishes to wash: 1 board or plate

EFFORT: 5 MIN NO COOKING

This is the dinner for the person who has completely given up and is quietly thriving. It's cheese, crackers, meat, fruit and crunchy things, arranged on a plate so it looks like a decision.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

8 oz cheese (cheddar, Colby or Swiss), cubed or sliced

1 sleeve crackers

6 oz deli meat or salami

1 cup grapes or apple slices

1/2 cup nuts

1 cup baby carrots or sliced cucumber

1/2 cup pickles or olives

Hummus or ranch for dipping

HOW TO MAKE IT

Grab the biggest plate or cutting board you own.

Put the cheese in one area and fan the crackers beside it. Group the meat, fruit, nuts and vegetables in their own little piles.

Fill any gaps with pickles, olives or whatever's open in the fridge. Add a small bowl of dip.

Eat on the couch. This is not a drill.

Even lazier:
Buy a pre-made snack tray at the store and skip the arranging.

Good to know:
Add protein with hard-boiled eggs or leftover chicken. A balanced board needs something filling, not just crackers.

6. Microwave Chili Potatoes

Dishes to wash: 1 bowl

EFFORT: 5 MIN of effort MICROWAVE

The microwave bakes a potato in a few minutes, and a can of chili does the rest. It’s a baked potato dinner with a trench coat and a plan.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

2 to 4 large russet potatoes

1 can (15 oz) chili with beans

1 cup shredded cheddar

Optional: sour cream, green onion, hot sauce

HOW TO MAKE IT

Scrub the potatoes and poke each one 8 to 10 times with a fork so steam can escape.

Microwave on a plate: about 5 to 6 minutes for one potato, plus 3 to 4 minutes for each additional potato. Flip them halfway through. They’re done when a knife slides in with no resistance. Let them sit 2 minutes. They’re very hot.

Meanwhile, put the chili in a microwave-safe bowl. Never microwave the can. Cover loosely and heat 2 minutes, stirring halfway, until steaming hot.

Slice each potato open lengthwise, squeeze the ends to open it up, and fluff with a fork.

Spoon on the chili, then the cheese. Add sour cream if you like.

Even lazier:
Skip the toppings and just butter the potato. Still counts.

Good to know:
Use oven mitts or a dish towel when handling the potatoes. They hold heat for a long time.

Level 2: Fifteen Minutes (the "I Can Stand Upright" Tier)

You have enough energy to turn on a burner, but not enough to chop an onion. These dinners need one pan or pot, a handful of shortcuts and about fifteen minutes of low-key effort. Think of it as cooking with training wheels on.

7. Tortellini with Jarred Sauce and Spinach

Dishes to wash: 1 pot + colander

EFFORT: 15 MIN STOVETOP

Refrigerated tortellini is a pasta that arrives already stuffed with cheese. That means you get the effort of making ravioli with the effort of boiling water. A jar of sauce does the rest.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 package (20 oz) refrigerated cheese tortellini

1 jar (24 oz) marinara sauce

3 cups baby spinach

1/2 cup grated Parmesan or shredded mozzarella

Salt for the water

HOW TO MAKE IT

Fill a large pot about two-thirds full with water, add a big pinch of salt, and bring to a boil.

Add the tortellini and cook according to the package, usually 3 to 5 minutes. They're done when they float and feel tender when you bite one.

In the last 30 seconds, toss in the spinach. It'll wilt right in the pot.

Scoop out 1/2 cup of the pasta water with a mug, then drain the tortellini in a colander.

Return the pot to low heat, add the tortellini and sauce, and stir 2 minutes until hot. If it's too thick, add a splash of the pasta water.

Top with cheese and eat.

Even lazier:
Skip the spinach. Use sauce and cheese only.

Good to know:
Fresh tortellini cook much faster than dried pasta. Keep an eye on the pot so they don't overcook and split.

8. Egg Fried Rice

Dishes to wash: 1 skillet

EFFORT: 15 MIN STOVETOP

Fried rice was invented as a way to rescue leftovers, which makes it the patron saint of lazy dinners. Microwave rice pouches are just as good as leftover rice, and nobody can tell the difference.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

2 microwave rice pouches (8.8 oz each), or 3 cups cold cooked rice

4 eggs, beaten

1 bag (12 oz) frozen peas and carrots

3 tbsp soy sauce

2 tbsp cooking oil

2 garlic cloves, minced (or 1/2 tsp garlic powder)

Optional: green onions, sesame oil, leftover chicken

HOW TO MAKE IT

Microwave the rice pouches for 90 seconds, then squeeze the pouch to break up any clumps.

Heat the oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the frozen vegetables and cook 3 minutes, stirring, until hot.

Push the vegetables to one side. Pour the eggs into the empty space and stir 1 minute until just set, then mix them into the vegetables.

Add the rice and press it into the pan. Let it sit 1 to 2 minutes without stirring so it gets crispy and golden underneath, then stir. Repeat once.

Add the garlic and soy sauce, stir for 1 minute, and taste. Add more soy sauce if needed.

Even lazier:
Use eggs and rice only and skip the vegetables.

Good to know:
Cold, dry rice gets crispier than fresh, steamy rice. Spread the microwaved rice on a plate for a few minutes first if you have the patience.

9. Skillet Gnocchi with Sausage and Spinach

Dishes to wash: 1 skillet

EFFORT: 15 MIN STOVETOP

Shelf-stable gnocchi go straight into the pan, no boiling, no draining, no second pot. They crisp up like tiny potato pillows. It's the closest thing to dinner magic that doesn't involve a wand.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 package (16 to 18 oz) shelf-stable potato gnocchi

12 oz fully cooked smoked sausage or chicken sausage, sliced

1 tbsp oil

1 1/2 cups marinara or Alfredo sauce (jarred)

3 cups baby spinach

1/2 cup grated Parmesan

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oil in a large skillet over medium-high heat. Add the gnocchi in a single layer, straight from the package.

Cook 5 to 6 minutes, stirring only every minute or so, until golden and slightly crisp on the outside.

Add the sliced sausage and cook 2 to 3 minutes, until it’s browned at the edges.

Pour in the sauce, reduce the heat to medium-low, and simmer 2 minutes. Stir in the spinach and cook 1 minute, until wilted.

Top with Parmesan and serve straight from the skillet.

Even lazier:
Skip the spinach and serve with a pre-made salad kit.

Good to know:
Use the gnocchi from the pasta aisle (shelf-stable), not the refrigerated or frozen kind. They behave differently in the pan.

10. Sheet-Pan Nachos

Dishes to wash: 0 (foil-lined pan)

EFFORT: 15 MIN OVEN

Nachos are what happens when dinner stops trying to impress you and just wants to be your friend. It’s chips and cheese, and you can add as much or as little as you like. A sheet of foil means the pan stays clean.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

1 bag (10 to 13 oz) tortilla chips

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained and rinsed

2 cups shredded cheese

1 cup shredded rotisserie chicken (optional)

1 jar salsa

Toppings: sour cream, avocado, cilantro, sliced jalape os

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oven to 400 F. Line a large rimmed baking sheet with foil.

Spread the chips across the pan in an even layer, piling them slightly in the middle.

Scatter the beans and chicken over the chips, then cover with cheese. Be generous. More cheese reaching more chips means better nachos.

Bake 8 to 10 minutes, until the cheese is melted and bubbling at the edges. Watch closely at the end, since the chips can burn quickly.

Top with salsa, sour cream and whatever else you have. Eat right from the pan.

Even lazier:
Use only chips and cheese. It’s still nachos.

Good to know:
Layer the toppings in two rounds (chips, toppings, chips, toppings) so every chip gets some love.

11. Lemon-Garlic Butter Pasta with Peas

Dishes to wash: 1 pot + colander

EFFORT: 15 MIN STOVETOP

This is pasta at its most basic and most beautiful: butter, garlic, lemon and a handful of peas that you didn’t have to chop. It tastes like a restaurant, but it’s mostly pantry staples.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

12 oz spaghetti or linguine

4 tbsp butter

3 garlic cloves, minced (or 1 tsp garlic powder)

1 cup frozen peas

Juice of 1/2 lemon (or 2 tbsp bottled lemon juice)

1/2 cup grated Parmesan

Salt and black pepper

HOW TO MAKE IT

Boil the pasta in a large pot of well-salted water, according to the package. Add the frozen peas in the last minute of cooking.

Before draining, scoop out 1/2 cup of the starchy pasta water with a mug. Then drain the pasta and peas in a colander.

Put the empty pot back on low heat. Add the butter and garlic and stir 30 seconds, just until you smell the garlic. Don’t let it brown.

Add the pasta and peas back to the pot with the lemon juice, Parmesan, a pinch of salt and lots of pepper. Toss, adding pasta water a splash at a time until the sauce is glossy and clings to the noodles.

Taste and adjust with more lemon, salt or cheese.

Even lazier:
Skip the lemon and add more Parmesan. Same comfort, less thinking.

Good to know:
That starchy pasta water is the secret. It helps the butter and cheese turn into a silky sauce instead of sliding off the noodles.

12. Naan Pizzas

Dishes to wash: 0 (foil-lined pan)

EFFORT: 15 MIN OVEN

Pizza delivery is a tradition, but it’s also $30 and a 45-minute wait. Naan pizzas take about the same time to bake as it takes to find your wallet. Naan is basically pre-made pizza crust that doesn’t know it’s famous.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

4 naan breads

1 cup marinara or pizza sauce

2 cups shredded mozzarella

Toppings: pepperoni, cooked sausage, olives, peppers, a drizzle of olive oil

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oven to 425 F. Line a large baking sheet with foil.

Set the naan on the sheet. Spread about 1/4 cup of sauce on each, leaving a small border.

Cover with cheese and add your toppings.

Bake 7 to 9 minutes, until the cheese is bubbling and the naan edges are golden.

Let cool 2 minutes (the cheese is lava), then cut with a pizza cutter or kitchen scissors.

Even lazier:
Each person tops their own. Instant buy-in from every member of the household.

Good to know:
For a crispier crust, bake the naan on its own for 2 minutes before adding the sauce.

13. Salsa Chicken Tacos (the Rotisserie Hack)

Dishes to wash: 1 skillet

EFFORT: 10 to 15 MIN STOVETOP

Tacos have a reputation for being a lot of work, but only if you season and cook raw meat. With a rotisserie chicken, taco night is about as hard as reheating leftovers, and the chicken's already seasoned.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 store-bought rotisserie chicken (about 3 to 4 cups shredded)

1 cup salsa

1 tsp ground cumin

8 to 12 small tortillas

Toppings: shredded lettuce or cabbage, cheese, sour cream, lime, avocado

HOW TO MAKE IT

Pull the chicken meat off the bones and shred it into bite-size pieces, discarding the skin if you like. Wash your hands afterward.

Put the chicken, salsa and cumin in a large skillet over medium heat. Stir 4 to 5 minutes, until the chicken is steaming hot all the way through and the sauce has thickened slightly.

Wrap the tortillas in a damp paper towel and microwave 30 seconds, until soft and warm.

Set out the chicken and the toppings in bowls, and let everyone build their own.

Even lazier:
Skip the toppings. Chicken and a tortilla is a taco.

Good to know:
Reheated leftovers should reach 165 F. If you're not sure, add 2 more minutes in the pan.

Level 3: Dump-and-Go (the "Future Me Will Handle It" Tier)

This is the tier for people who have a little energy now and want to spend it all at once, so that dinner takes care of itself later. You dump ingredients into a slow cooker, sheet pan or baking dish, walk away, and your
future self

takes the credit. Future you is going to be so grateful.

14. Slow Cooker Honey Garlic Meatballs

Dishes to wash: 1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

EFFORT: 5 MIN SLOW COOKER

Frozen meatballs are the lazy cook's secret weapon: fully cooked, pre-seasoned and ready to be adopted by a sauce. This sticky, sweet and garlicky sauce is made by whisking five things in a measuring cup.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 bag (about 28 oz) frozen fully cooked meatballs

1/2 cup honey

1/3 cup soy sauce

1/4 cup ketchup

4 garlic cloves, minced (or 1 tsp garlic powder)

1 bag (12 oz) frozen broccoli

2 microwave rice pouches, for serving

HOW TO MAKE IT

Spray the slow cooker with cooking spray or use a slow cooker liner.

Pour the frozen meatballs into the cooker.

In a measuring cup, whisk the honey, soy sauce, ketchup and garlic. Pour over the meatballs and stir gently to coat.

Cover and cook on LOW for 4 hours or HIGH for 2 hours, until the meatballs are hot all the way through (165 F).

Add the frozen broccoli on top for the last 30 minutes.

Microwave the rice pouches, then serve the meatballs and sauce over the rice.

Even lazier:
Skip the broccoli and serve with a bag of salad.

Good to know:
Sauce too thin? Take the lid off for the last 20 minutes on HIGH so it thickens.

15. Sheet-Pan Kielbasa, Potatoes and Green Beans

Dishes to wash: 0 (foil-lined pan)

EFFORT: 10 MIN OVEN

Everything goes on one pan, the oven does the work, and the kielbasa seasons the vegetables as it roasts. It’s what dinner would look like if it were also your best employee.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

1 lb smoked kielbasa, sliced into 1/2-inch rounds

1 1/2 lb baby potatoes, halved

12 oz fresh green beans, trimmed

3 tbsp olive oil, divided

1 tsp garlic powder

1 tsp paprika

Salt and pepper

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oven to 425 F. Line a large rimmed baking sheet with foil.

Toss the potatoes on the pan with 1 1/2 tbsp oil, half the garlic powder and paprika, 1/2 tsp salt and some pepper. Spread in a single layer, cut-side down.

Roast 15 minutes. Potatoes need a head start because they take the longest.

Add the kielbasa and green beans to the pan with the remaining oil and spices. Toss everything with a spatula.

Roast 18 to 20 more minutes, stirring once halfway, until the potatoes are golden and tender and the green beans are lightly browned.

Serve right off the pan.

Even lazier:
Use frozen baby potatoes and a bag of fresh-cut green beans to skip chopping entirely.

Good to know:
If the pan looks crowded, split everything between two pans. Crowded food steams instead of roasting.

16. Dump-and-Go Taco Soup

Dishes to wash: 1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

EFFORT: 5 MIN SLOW COOKER

It’s a soup made by opening five cans and a packet. If a recipe can be made while you stand in a kitchen in your socks, it’s a good recipe. Top it with chips, and it becomes

a bowl of taco night.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 1/2 lb boneless, skinless chicken breasts (thawed)

1 can (15 oz) black beans, drained

1 can (15 oz) kidney or pinto beans, drained

1 can (15 oz) corn, drained

1 can (10 oz) diced tomatoes with green chilies

2 cups chicken broth

1 packet taco seasoning

Toppings: tortilla chips, shredded cheese, sour cream

HOW TO MAKE IT

Put the chicken in the bottom of the slow cooker.

Dump in the beans, corn, tomatoes (with their juice), broth and taco seasoning. Stir lightly.

Cover and cook on LOW for 6 to 7 hours (or HIGH for 3 to 4 hours), until the chicken reaches 165 F and shreds easily.

Using two forks, shred the chicken right in the pot and stir it back into the soup.

Taste, add salt if needed, and ladle into bowls. Top with crushed chips, cheese and sour cream.

Even lazier:
Skip the toppings except chips. The soup stands on its own.

Good to know:
Thaw chicken in the fridge before using it in a slow cooker. Frozen meat takes too long to heat up in there.

17. Dump-and-Bake Chicken and Rice

Dishes to wash: 1 baking dish

EFFORT: 10 MIN OVEN

Raw rice, broth and chicken go into a baking dish, you cover it with foil, and the oven does all the cooking. No stirring, no watching, no pot. It's like a casserole that skipped all the steps.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 1/2 cups long-grain white rice (not instant)

3 cups hot chicken broth

1 1/2 lb boneless, skinless chicken thighs (about 6)

1 bag (12 oz) frozen broccoli or mixed vegetables

1 tsp garlic powder

1 tsp paprika

1 tsp salt, 1/2 tsp pepper

1 cup shredded cheddar (optional)

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oven to 375 F. Heat the broth in the microwave for 3 minutes (hot liquid helps the rice cook evenly).

Pour the rice into a 9x13-inch baking dish. Sprinkle with half the garlic powder, paprika and salt. Pour the hot broth over and stir once.

Lay the chicken thighs on top and sprinkle with the remaining spices and pepper.

Cover the dish tightly with foil. A good seal traps the steam. Bake 45 minutes.

Carefully peel back the foil (watch out for the steam), scatter the frozen vegetables over the top, re-cover, and bake 10 to 15 more minutes, until the rice is tender and the chicken reaches 165 F.

Sprinkle on the cheese, if using, and let it melt for 3 minutes. Let the dish rest 5 minutes, then fluff the rice with a fork.

Even lazier:
Skip the vegetables and serve with a bag of salad on the side.

Good to know:
If the rice is still crunchy, add 1/4 cup hot water, re-cover, and bake 10 more minutes.

18. Slow Cooker Baked Potato Bar

Dishes to wash: 0 (potatoes stay wrapped in foil)

EFFORT: 5 MIN SLOW COOKER

Wrap some potatoes in foil in the morning, and by evening you have the base for a baked potato bar. There’s no oven preheating, no hovering, and the house smells like you’re a person who has things handled.

WHAT YOU’LL NEED

6 medium russet potatoes

Aluminum foil

1 tbsp oil and 1 tsp salt

Toppings: butter, shredded cheese, sour cream, chili, bacon bits, steamed broccoli, green onions

HOW TO MAKE IT

Scrub the potatoes and poke each one several times with a fork. Rub with a little oil and sprinkle with salt.

Wrap each potato in a sheet of foil. Stack them in the slow cooker. Don't add any water.

Cover and cook on LOW 7 to 8 hours, or HIGH 4 to 5 hours, until a fork slides into the center with no resistance.

Carefully unwrap each one (steam alert), slice open lengthwise and fluff the inside with a fork.

Set out the toppings and let everyone build their own.

Even lazier:
Microwave leftover chili or heat a can of soup as a topping and call it a day.

Good to know:
Potatoes are done when a fork slides in easily. Cooking times vary by slow cooker, so check at the minimum time.

19. Dump-and-Bake Ziti

Dishes to wash: 1 baking dish

EFFORT: 10 MIN OVEN

The best thing about baked ziti is that the pasta never needs to be boiled. It bakes in sauce, soaks up all the flavor and comes out cheesy and tender. It's a casserole you can assemble in 5 minutes, in a dish you'll wash once.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

1 lb ziti or penne (uncooked)

2 jars (24 oz each) marinara sauce

1 1/2 cups hot water

1 cup ricotta cheese (optional)

2 cups shredded mozzarella, divided

1 tsp Italian seasoning

1/2 tsp salt

HOW TO MAKE IT

Heat the oven to 375 F.

Pour the dry pasta into a 9x13-inch baking dish. Add the marinara, hot water, Italian seasoning and salt. Stir until every piece of pasta is submerged. Dot with ricotta and 1 cup of the mozzarella and stir in lightly.

Cover the dish very tightly with foil. Bake 50 to 55 minutes.

Carefully remove the foil (steam!). Stir, and check that the pasta is tender. If it's still firm, re-cover and bake 5 to 10 more minutes.

Sprinkle with the remaining cheese and bake uncovered 8 to 10 minutes, until bubbly and golden.

Let it stand 10 minutes. The sauce thickens as it cools.

Even lazier:
Skip the ricotta. Cheese on top is all you need.

Good to know:
Make sure all the pasta is covered by liquid. Any exposed pieces will bake up crunchy.

20. Slow Cooker BBQ Pulled Chicken Sandwiches

Dishes to wash: 1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

EFFORT: 5 MIN SLOW COOKER

Two ingredients (chicken and BBQ sauce) and a little patience make a sandwich that tastes like you worked on it all day. You'll have shredded, saucy chicken to pile on buns, and probably a plan for leftovers.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

2 lb boneless, skinless chicken breasts

1 1/2 cups BBQ sauce

1/2 cup chicken broth or water

6 to 8 hamburger buns

Optional: coleslaw, pickles, shredded cheese

HOW TO MAKE IT

Place the chicken in the slow cooker. Pour the BBQ sauce and broth over the top.

Cover and cook on LOW 5 to 6 hours or HIGH 3 hours, until the chicken reaches 165 F and shreds easily.

Shred the chicken with two forks right in the pot. Stir to coat in the sauce, and let it sit 10 minutes to soak up the flavor.

Toast the buns if you have the energy.

Pile the chicken on the buns and add coleslaw or pickles.

Even lazier:
Serve the chicken over rice with no bun, and use one fewer pan.

Good to know:
Use leftovers over baked potatoes, in quesadillas or on a pizza.

Cheats That Aren’t Cheating: Store-Bought Shortcuts That Actually Work

Professional cooks use shortcuts all the time. You’re in good company. These are the ones that earn their spot in
your cart
.

Shortcut

What it replaces

Used in

Rotisserie chicken

Cooking and shredding chicken

#1, 3, 10, 13

Microwave rice pouches

Cooking rice (and the pot)

#2, 8, 14

Jarred marinara or Alfredo

Making a sauce

#7, 9, 12, 19

Frozen vegetables

Washing, chopping and peeling

#4, 8, 14, 17

Refrigerated tortellini

Boiling and filling pasta

#7

Shelf-stable gnocchi

Boiling potatoes and dumplings

#9

Naan

Making pizza dough

#12

Frozen cooked meatballs

Mixing and rolling meatballs

#14

Canned beans

Soaking and boiling dry beans

#2, 6, 10, 16

Pre-shredded cheese

Grating

most of the list

The one rule:
check the label. Some shortcuts (like canned soup, jarred sauces and seasoning packets) can be high in sodium. If that's a concern, taste before adding salt and use half the packet.

How to Wash Fewer Dishes (the Sneaky Time-Saver)

The best part of a lazy dinner is that it should leave a lazy sink. A few small tricks make cleanup a non-event:

Line it.
Foil or parchment on a sheet pan means the pan basically stays clean (#10, 12, 15). Slow cooker liners do the same for slow cookers (#14, 16, 20).

Fill the sink first.
Run a few inches of hot, soapy water before you start. Drop in each bowl or utensil as you finish with it, so nothing dries on.

Use the serving bowl as the mixing bowl.
Microwave and mix in the same bowl you'll eat from (#2).

Pick one-pot meals.
Cooking pasta, sauce and protein in the same pot (or skillet) turns three dishes into one (#7, 9, 11).

Use kitchen scissors.
They cut pizza, bacon, herbs and naan without a knife and cutting board.

Eat from the pan.
Nobody can stop you. Fewer plates, fewer forks, more couch.

Lazy Dinners FAQ

What can I make for dinner when I really don't feel like cooking?
Start with the Level 1 dinners in this list: they use rotisserie chicken, microwave rice, canned beans and tortillas and take about five minutes of effort. If you have a little more energy, try a Level 2 one-pan dinner. If you can prep in the morning, a Level 3 slow cooker or oven dinner does the work for you.

What's the easiest dinner with the fewest dishes?
Hummus veggie wraps, the rotisserie chicken plate and sheet-pan nachos all leave 0 dishes to wash if you line the pan. One-pot pastas and skillet dinners leave one.

Are lazy dinners healthy?
They can be. Many of the dinners here use vegetables, beans, eggs or chicken. Frozen vegetables are a convenient way to add more of them. Check labels on store-bought shortcuts if you're watching sodium. If you have specific dietary needs, talk with your doctor or a registered dietitian.

How can I make lazy dinners for a family?
Dump-and-go dinners (Level 3) feed a crowd with almost no extra effort. Build-your-own dinners (nachos, tacos, baked potatoes) let everyone customize their plate, which helps picky eaters.

Pick Your Energy Level and Go

Look at where your brain is right now. Houseplant? Level 1. Upright? Level 2. Generous to your future self? Level 3. There's no wrong answer, and no bonus points for suffering. Pick one, make it, wash the three things, and put your feet up. You did dinner. That's the whole assignment.

Save this pin for the next 5:47 p.m. pop quiz, and get the free printable "tired-night dinner" cheat sheet through our
email delivery page
, or skip ahead to the
full Rescue Kit
.

Keep reading:
Cheap Family Dinners

Sheet Pan vs. Slow Cooker

Weeknight Dinner Mistakes

Our Weekly Meal Plan

Disclosure: this post may contain affiliate links for items like parchment paper, slow cooker liners, and an instant-read thermometer. If you buy through them, I may earn a small commission at no extra cost to you.

Free Printable: Energy Level Dinner Picker

Tape this to the fridge. When someone asks what’s for dinner, point to the column that matches how you feel. Want it to pick for you and write the grocery list? That’s what the
Rescue Kit
does.

LEVEL 1 5 MINUTES (houseplant)

Effort

Dishes

1. Rotisserie Chicken Plate (the Adult Lunchable)

5 MIN

0 (just plates)

2. 5-Minute Burrito Bowl

5 MIN

1 bowl

3. Hummus Veggie Wraps

5 MIN

0

4. Upgraded Instant Ramen

5 to 7 MIN

1 pot

5. Snack Board Dinner

5 MIN

1 board or plate

6. Microwave Chili Potatoes

5 MIN of effort

1 bowl

LEVEL 2 15 MINUTES (upright)

Effort

Dishes

7. Tortellini with Jarred Sauce and Spinach

15 MIN

1 pot + colander

8. Egg Fried Rice

15 MIN

1 skillet

9. Skillet Gnocchi with Sausage and Spinach

15 MIN

1 skillet

10. Sheet-Pan Nachos

15 MIN

0 (foil-lined pan)

11. Lemon-Garlic Butter Pasta with Peas

15 MIN

1 pot + colander

12. Naan Pizzas

15 MIN

0 (foil-lined pan)

13. Salsa Chicken Tacos (the Rotisserie Hack)

10 to 15 MIN

1 skillet

LEVEL 3 DUMP-AND-GO (future me)

Effort

Dishes

14. Slow Cooker Honey Garlic Meatballs

5 MIN

1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

15. Sheet-Pan Kielbasa, Potatoes and Green Beans

10 MIN

0 (foil-lined pan)

16. Dump-and-Go Taco Soup

5 MIN

1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

17. Dump-and-Bake Chicken and Rice

10 MIN

1 baking dish

18. Slow Cooker Baked Potato Bar

5 MIN

0 (potatoes stay wrapped in foil)

19. Dump-and-Bake Ziti

10 MIN

1 baking dish

20. Slow Cooker BBQ Pulled Chicken Sandwiches

5 MIN

1 slow cooker (0 with a liner)

My own lazy dinners:

Dinner

Level

Effort

Dishes

More easy-dinner guides

Keep dinner simple with these related guides:

Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Cheap Family Dinners With Cost Per Serving

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Pantry Staples for Budget Cooking

Sheet Pan vs. Slow Cooker vs. One Pot vs. Air Fryer

Trusted food and nutrition resources

USDA MyPlate: balanced eating guidance

FoodSafety.gov: safe minimum cooking temperatures

USDA FSIS: leftovers and food safety

Make tomorrow's dinner even easier.

Your free resource is yours to keep. If you'd like more help, these optional tools make real-life meal planning easier.

DINNER PLANNING MADE SIMPLE

The 5:47 P.M. Rescue Kit

Find low-effort dinners based on how much energy you have, plus useful planning tools for busy evenings.

EXPLORE THE RESCUE KIT

SHOP SMARTER FOR FAMILY MEALS

The Cheap Dinner Vault

Compare low-cost dinner ideas and practical meal-budget approaches to get more from your groceries.

EXPLORE BUDGET DINNERS

Both resources are optional. Your free printable does not require a purchase.